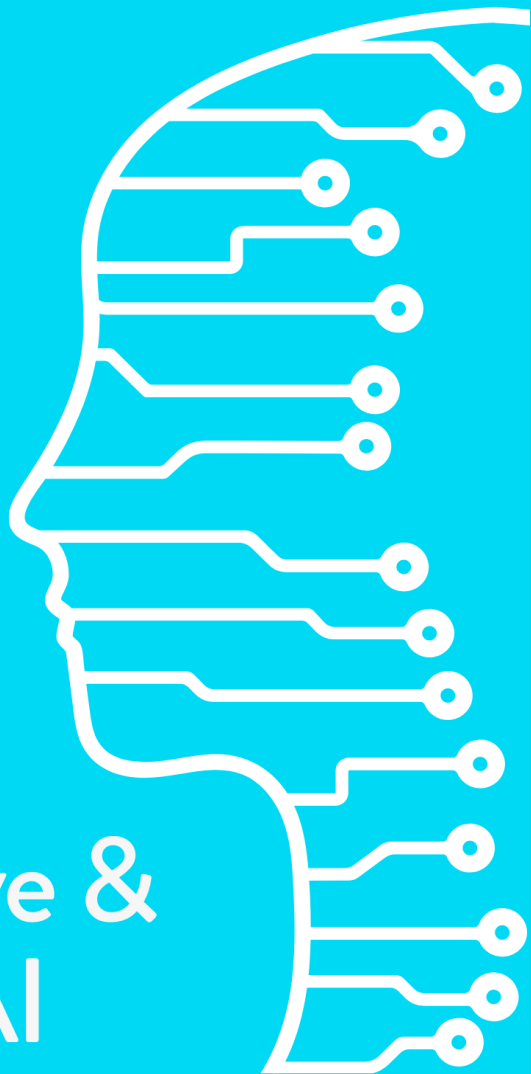


SparkOptimus



Generative & Agentic AI

Guidelines for (supervisory) boards

December 2025

What Gen AI means for boards

Gen AI & Agentic AI are moving faster than anything we have seen before. The pace of innovation, adoption and hype is unprecedented, and every week brings new breakthroughs, new products and new promises.

Yet the impact remains limited. Although a majority of companies now indicate they're running experiments with Gen AI across functions, many initiatives stall in the pilot phase and fail to scale across the organization.

At SparkOptimus, we have seen these dynamics before, as the past 15 years of digital transformation offer valuable lessons. Despite massive investments, organizations captured only a fraction of potential value due to lack of focus, siloed execution, outsourcing digital to IT, and a lack of reinvestment into customer value. Gen AI risks following the same pattern, unless Boards ensure strategic focus and disciplined execution.

Productivity gains are real, but the true challenge lies in steering organizations through structural disruption that's only just beginning.

This booklet is written to act as guidance for boards (and to provide insight to supervisory boards) based on our lessons learnt: to understand the impact of Gen AI, and to grasp how to steer and govern through this disruption to make real impact possible.



Matti van Engelen
Associate partner &
AI Lead



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Today: Productivity

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Most organizations focus on realizing productivity gains in individual functions today, although real impact is rare

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But productivity alone is not enough; Gen AI will fundamentally change the customer experience, and you need to adapt

Lead the change...

3

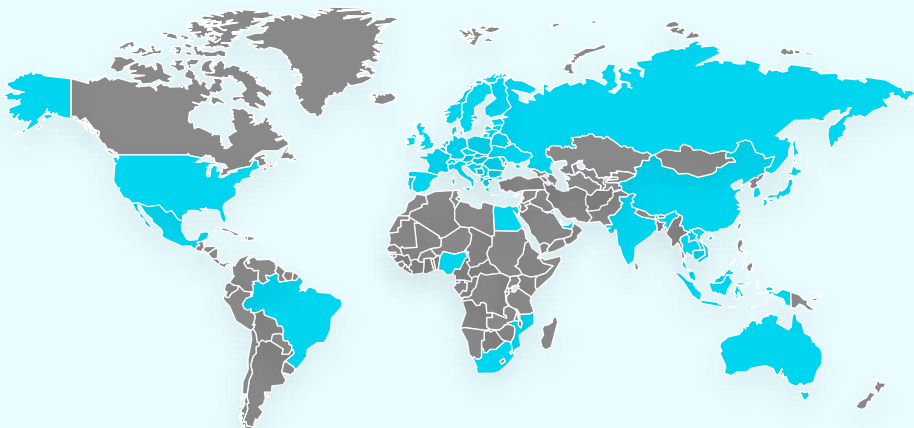
While Gen AI is a complex technology, realizing impact requires a structured and considered approach towards value creation

... based on a strong foundation

4

To ensure success at scale, build on a people-focused foundation and pay the required attention to data, security, legal and ethics

About SparkOptimus



S

Execution-focused strategy consultancy with 100% focus on business transformation in the face of Digital and Gen AI disruption

S

Deep heritage with early digital-native disruptors (e.g., Bol.com, eBay, and JustEatTakeAway) since 2010

S

Driving immediate business value with self-funding programs, while managing change and building capabilities

S

1500+ projects for clients across the globe, at headquarters and on-the-ground in local markets



1

Today: Productivity

2022



2024



Prompt:

"A classic diner restaurant called Joe's in large neon letters"

2025



White-collar productivity is the name of the game (for now)

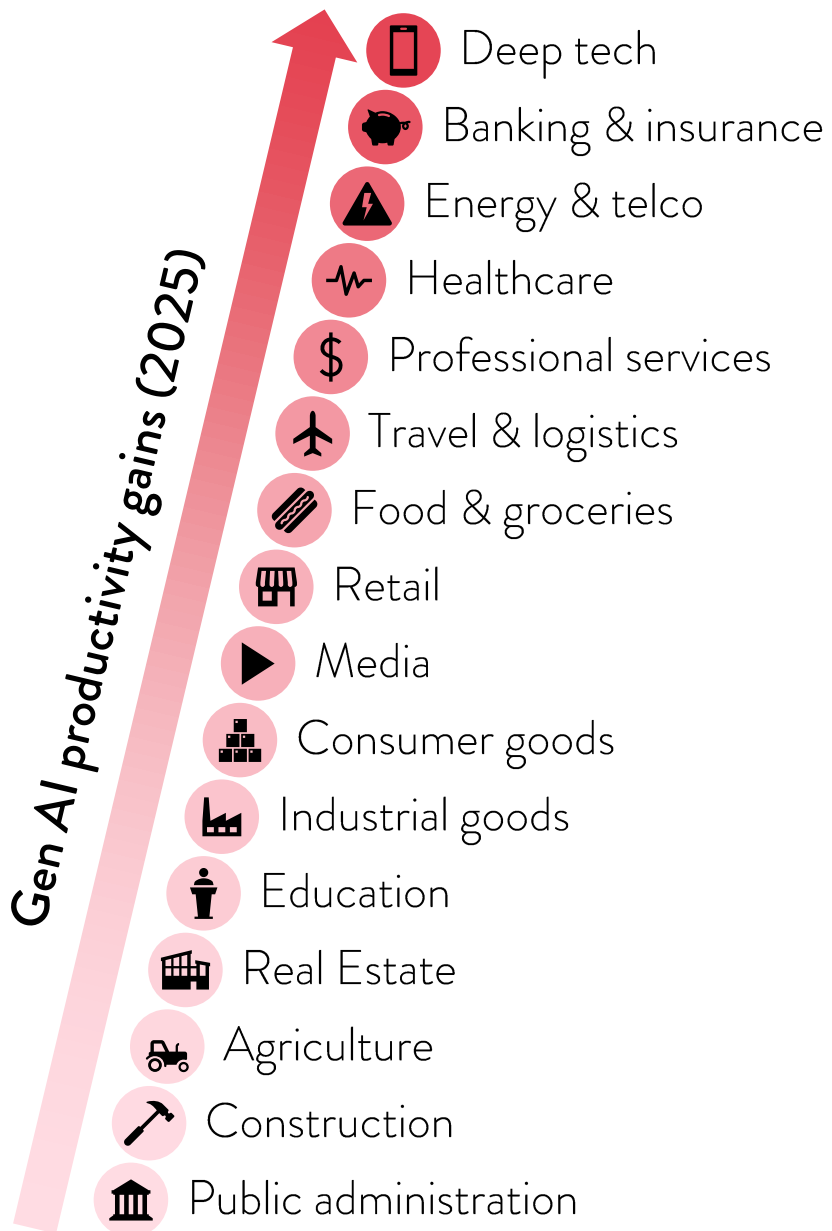
Almost every company is now experimenting with Gen AI to boost productivity. Initial focus is often on simple use cases leveraging out-of-the-box Gen AI models, like ChatGPT or Gemini. Examples include sales support, marketing content generation, legal document review, knowledge bases, and IT development.

The impact is real for frontrunners: SparkOptimus benchmarks show best-in-class productivity gains of 70% in customer service (e.g., AI chatbots and increasingly voice bots), 50% in marketing (e.g., ideation and content creation), and 40% in software development (e.g., code creation and bug fixing), with other functions following closely behind. All this only 3 years after the launch of ChatGPT; no other technology has realized impact this quickly.

And we aren't finished yet. Models continue to improve at tremendous speed and companies are only just starting to learn how to truly leverage this technology and integrate it in their organization. The rise of agentic AI offers even more possibilities.

Industry example

One of our first clients in the Gen AI space was an FMCG player that wanted to move marketing campaign creation in-house in 2023. However, image generation models proved incapable of generating the realism needed for large-scale campaigns and the use case was put on hold. Just 2 years later 90% of images are now partly or fully generated by AI.



2

Sectors with FTE-heavy operational functions & standardized processes lead

Deep tech, banking & insurance and energy & telco are emerging as the leaders in Gen AI adoption because their personnel-heavy operational functions, with very standardized processes, offer the fastest and most tangible cost benefits. These sectors rely on large, relatively uniform activities such as content production, software engineering, customer service, underwriting, and claims processing. Gen AI slots directly into these tasks, automating routine work and reducing manual load rapidly.

The economics are straightforward. Even modest levels of automation in these environments generate significant savings and sharper efficiency. That is why these sectors are currently ahead: they feel the operational impact first, and the ROI is already too compelling to wait.

Industry example

A client in the energy & telecom sector sought to implement Gen AI in its customer service processes. After identifying relevant use cases, the first pilots saw 15% time savings in CS functions just 6 months after ChatGPT first launched. Now, these time savings have scaled up to 40%.

Typical evolution of Gen AI implementation today

Tier 1

General chatbots

“All employees have access to Copilot for individual productivity”

Tier 2

Customized chatbots

“Employees build their own custom chatbots for specific tasks”

Tier 3

Integration with proprietary data (RAG)

“Custom tools are built to integrate proprietary data supporting specific functions”

Tier 4

Agentic AI

“Networks of Gen AI agents work together to autonomously complete tasks”

Agentic AI solves increasingly complex problems with human-like collaboration

The impact of Gen AI on productivity isn't done yet. As mentioned, most organizations today focus on using general chatbot-type models (like ChatGPT) to support individual productivity or integrate models with proprietary data to support specific functions (e.g., customer service bots).

However, the rise of agentic AI means Gen AI systems can increasingly operate much like human teams: they coordinate toward shared goals, make decisions, discuss next steps, and take actions autonomously. This means Gen AI impact is shifting from automating individual tasks towards supporting more complex multi-step processes, with human support only at critical steps in the process

While this may sound complex, agents are essentially autonomous Gen AI models, paired with (proprietary) data, which will initially behave like “digital co-workers”. Each agent typically specializes in a specific task and communicates with other agents in natural language. Future agentic networks could act fully independently, automate a wide range of complex workflows that previously required coordinated human effort.

Industry example

One of our energy clients uses a series of Gen AI agents to develop marketing campaign materials, cutting campaign creation time by up to 50%. Within minutes, agents analyze the target audience, create ad content, design visuals, set up campaigns, and later report on performance.



Blue collar work will not be left alone

It is remarkable how text-based Gen AI models like ChatGPT, trained on nothing more than vast amounts of text, have developed a genuine understanding of language, grasping meaning, nuance, and context. But the next big breakthrough will probably come from video & world models. Trained only on raw footage, they are not simply generating video but are also beginning to understand the world itself; learning physics, movement, and cause and effect purely by watching.

Combining these new capabilities with the developments in robotics, general-purpose robots will come within reach. Google's recently revealed humanoid Gemini robot can sort trash, pack bags, fetch items, play games, search the internet, and much more. Other companies like Tesla are following suit, building impressive multi-purpose robots using Gen AI models. Others focus on tailoring these robots to specific domains like home care for the elderly, or logistics operations, opening up many new opportunities.

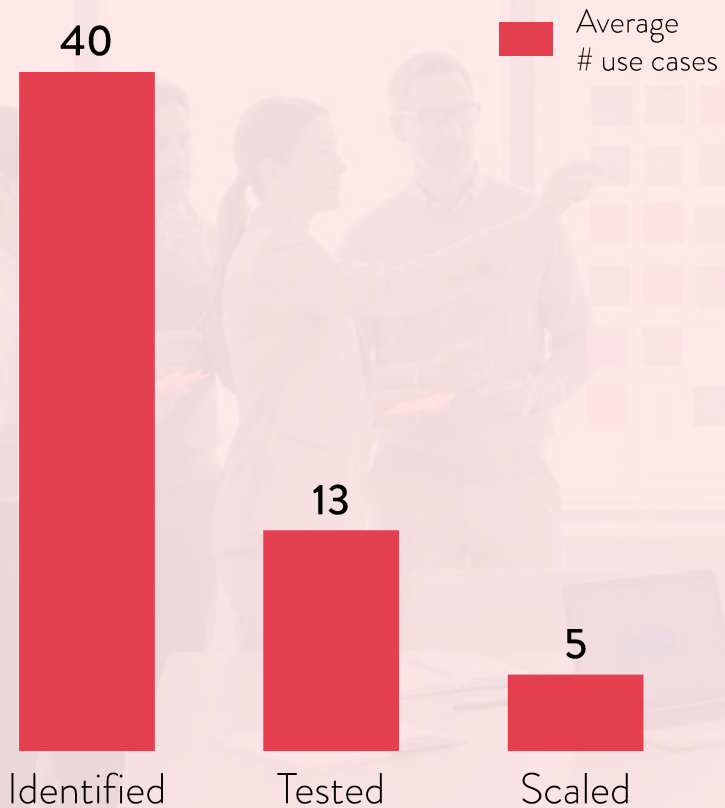
Industry example

An eyewear company was having issues realizing its fulfillment targets as it expanded, due to a manual picking & packing process. Using early Gen AI vision models, it employed robotic picking & packing robots to improve throughput by 80%.



SparkOptimus

**Only 12% of Gen AI initiatives
are successfully scaled**
(SparkOptimus Gen AI benchmark)



However, real impact is rare due to common pitfalls

Impact with Gen AI does not always materialize, with our benchmarks showing only 12% of Gen AI initiatives scale successfully across departments. This lack of impact is rarely a technology problem: only 25% of companies report Gen AI model quality as the limiting factor.

Instead, classic innovation pitfalls – like we’ve seen hundreds of times during Digital – are occurring with AI as well:

- 75% Lack of **strategy or quantified KPIs**
- 75% Missing **Gen AI skills and capabilities**
- 70% Execution in **silos/individual functions**
- 55% Insufficient **data quality or availability**
- 50% Lack of **management attention or alignment**
- 50% Initiatives **disconnected from the organization**
- 45% Lack of **change management or adoption support**
- 30% Hurdles in **legal or compliance when scaling**

Key lessons



White-collar productivity is the name of the game (for now)



Sectors with FTE-heavy operational functions & standardized processes lead



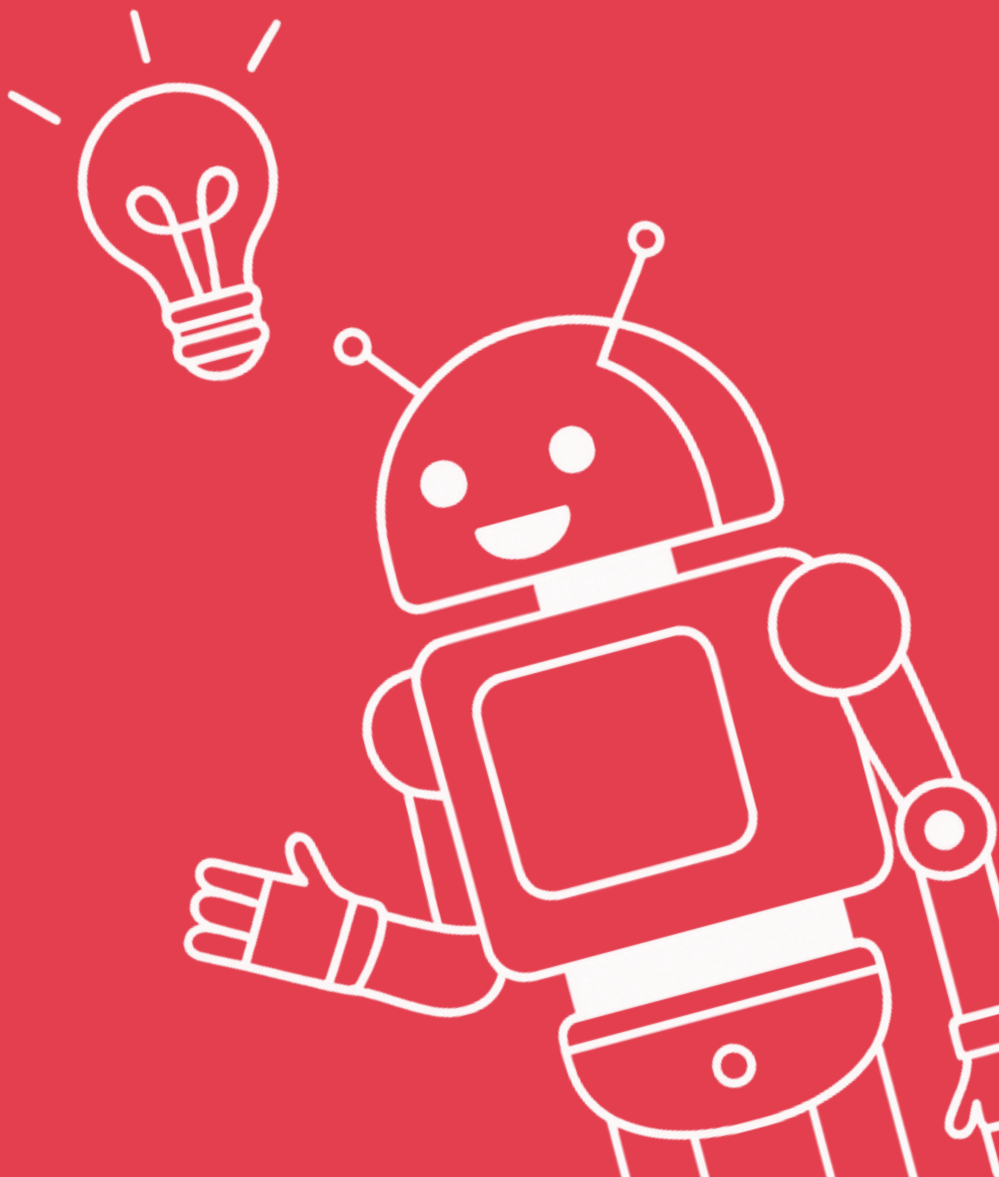
Agentic AI solves increasingly complex problems with human-like collaboration

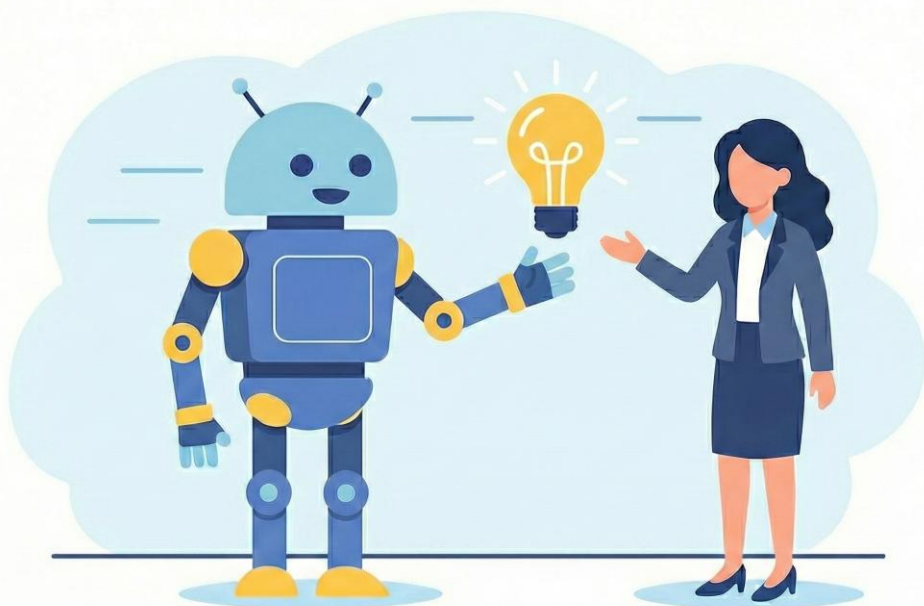


Blue collar work will not be left alone



However, real impact is rare due to common pitfalls





2

Tomorrow: reinvention



You can't beat disruption through productivity gains

Ultimately, dealing with disruption has never been about cutting costs but about redefining your proposition. Incumbents who are focused on cost-saving alone are overtaken by challengers who fundamentally reimagine how customer needs are met through new technologies and experiences. And as we'll see in the next few pages, Gen AI will completely reshape how customers interact with you.

Lessons from digital

In the 2000s, Thomas Cook was the go-to player for booking holidays. Their desk-bound agents held all the information: flights, hotels, and prices, while customers had to trust that what they were booking actually matched their needs and budget.

Thomas Cook could have optimized every part of that model: a new ERP system, improved workforce planning, or decreased wait times in stores. None of it would have prevented disruption by Booking.com, because Booking didn't focus on costs. It reinvented how customer needs were met by using digital to deliver transparency, speed, and control. Suddenly, travelers could see every hotel, compare prices and read reviews instantly.

11:30



ChatGPT 5 >



 Purchase complete



Dinnerware Set by
BlancPottery

Quantity: 1

Estimated delivery

Monday, September 29

Sold by

Etsy

Paid Etsy

\$81.47

[View details](#)

 Etsy confirmed your order! You'll get a confirmation email from Etsy soon. If you have questions, follow up with Etsy directly. You can view your order details anytime in Settings.



Ask anything



Gen AI will change our virtual interface

Gen AI companies are racing to become the new gateway to the internet. This ambition makes sense, because many people already use Gen AI much like they use Google: around 50% of all ChatGPT interactions are information-seeking & over 30% of teenagers already use chatbots daily.

To capture this interaction, companies like OpenAI and Google are expanding beyond chatbots. They are building full platforms that integrate browsing, advertising, and even instant shopping. ChatGPT, for example, now includes its own browser and check-out flow. Google is following suit, building an ecosystem around Search, Chrome, and Ads.

With over 1 billion monthly Gen AI chatbot users and growth surpassing that of the early internet, Gen AI is set to rival or even replace classic platforms as the default way people search, learn, and explore – although customers will do so in a fundamentally new way: through speech and human questioning, not keywords.

Lessons from digital

When Google emerged, it offered an intuitive and customer-focused way to find information, as opposed to the old human-curated internet directories. This quickly made it the primary gateway to the internet. For brands, not showing up on Google meant losing customers, because if you were not found there, you were invisible.



☁ 10°C

5:42



Gen AI will change our physical interface

The race to dominate Gen AI is moving beyond chatbots into the physical world. Tech giants are building AI-native devices, such as smart glasses, earbuds, and wearables, that will slowly replace or augment our phones.

Powered by models like ChatGPT, they give everyone access to a private “AI butler”, which is much more capable than today’s voice assistants. The reason people will shift to these new AI-enabled devices is that they offer a better and faster customer experience compared to phones (after all, phones require us to use our hands – impractical).

The rise of new devices and interfaces may open the next major business frontier. Users interacting through Gen AI devices may purchase specialized agents instead of apps and allow those agents to make transactions autonomously on their behalf.

Lessons from digital

From the introduction of the iPhone in 2007, it took only 5 years before 54% of the US population owned a smartphone. 2 years later, it was 75%. Technological shifts can happen fast, and companies need to follow suit.

Client example

Smartphones quickly reshaped customer behavior, with interactions moving to mobile platforms. The consequences for business models were dramatic, and companies that did not optimize their customer experiences for mobile rapidly lost market share. For example, a Dutch holiday website saw sales drop 30 percent in the early 2010s because its mobile conversion rate was 75% lower than its desktop conversion rate.



Key question to consider

How do I become or stay the primary touchpoint for my customers in the coming years?

Be where your customers are

The world is moving fast. Customers are already finding information and making decisions through AI agents rather than search engines. This means optimizing for agent interfaces, Gen AI discoverability, and agent payments, instead of Google visibility and search engine advertising. If you have a direct customer relationship, you have access to customer data, which allows you to shape customer expectations and set the standards for products and services, ultimately controlling the value chain.

Both AI-native entrants and generalists, such as OpenAI or Google, will aggressively compete for customers in any industry. Adaptive companies may well navigate this shift. However, more traditional organizations will need to think carefully about how to protect their customer relationships.

Lessons from digital

Netflix started building a Digital-native customer proposition, after realizing the benefits for customers. When they rapidly became the main interface for audiences, it was game over for traditional physical media players, as their customer touchpoint had been taken away.

Industry example

As B2B customers demanded faster and more digital interactions, many traditional players were slow to respond and risked losing ground to digital entrants. We helped a B2B agricultural wholesaler to build digital value-added services for all players in the entire value chain (from manufacturers to end-users), growing online sales to 90 percent.

*“Heads up, Edwin & Anna’s wedding is in 4 weeks on July 28th. **I pulled together 3 outfit ideas that fit your style and the event. Want a quick look?**”*



Key questions to consider

How can I serve my customers better at lower cost with Gen AI?

What is a best-in-class customer experience in 3 years?

Serve your customers better, faster, and easier

Customer needs don't change, but you can and must serve them better and at lower costs using Gen AI.

Whether it is a consumer wanting affordable fashion or a farmer striving for efficiency and sustainability, their needs are stable over time, and Gen AI simply allows you to meet them better and faster.

This isn't future talk. It is already happening, and it will redefine how every business serves its customers. For example, many ecommerce stores already include a customer-facing chatbot, allowing users to easily find and purchase relevant products.

As customers increasingly use Gen AI interfaces, with human-like interaction and voice controls, they will expect a similar experience in interacting with your business.

You need to think about how Gen AI will reshape the way your customers' needs are met for the better.

Lessons from digital

Customer expectations are often driven by their best experiences. Once customers got used to easy product filtering, rapid ordering, and simple payment on Amazon, they started expecting the same simplicity and speed everywhere, also in a B2B setting. One of our B2B clients had to rapidly build a digital service & ordering platform to remain relevant, which expanded the market, increased NPS, and reduced sales costs by 30%, while driving €10B+ annual sales.

Key lessons



You can't beat disruption through productivity gains



Gen AI will change our virtual interface



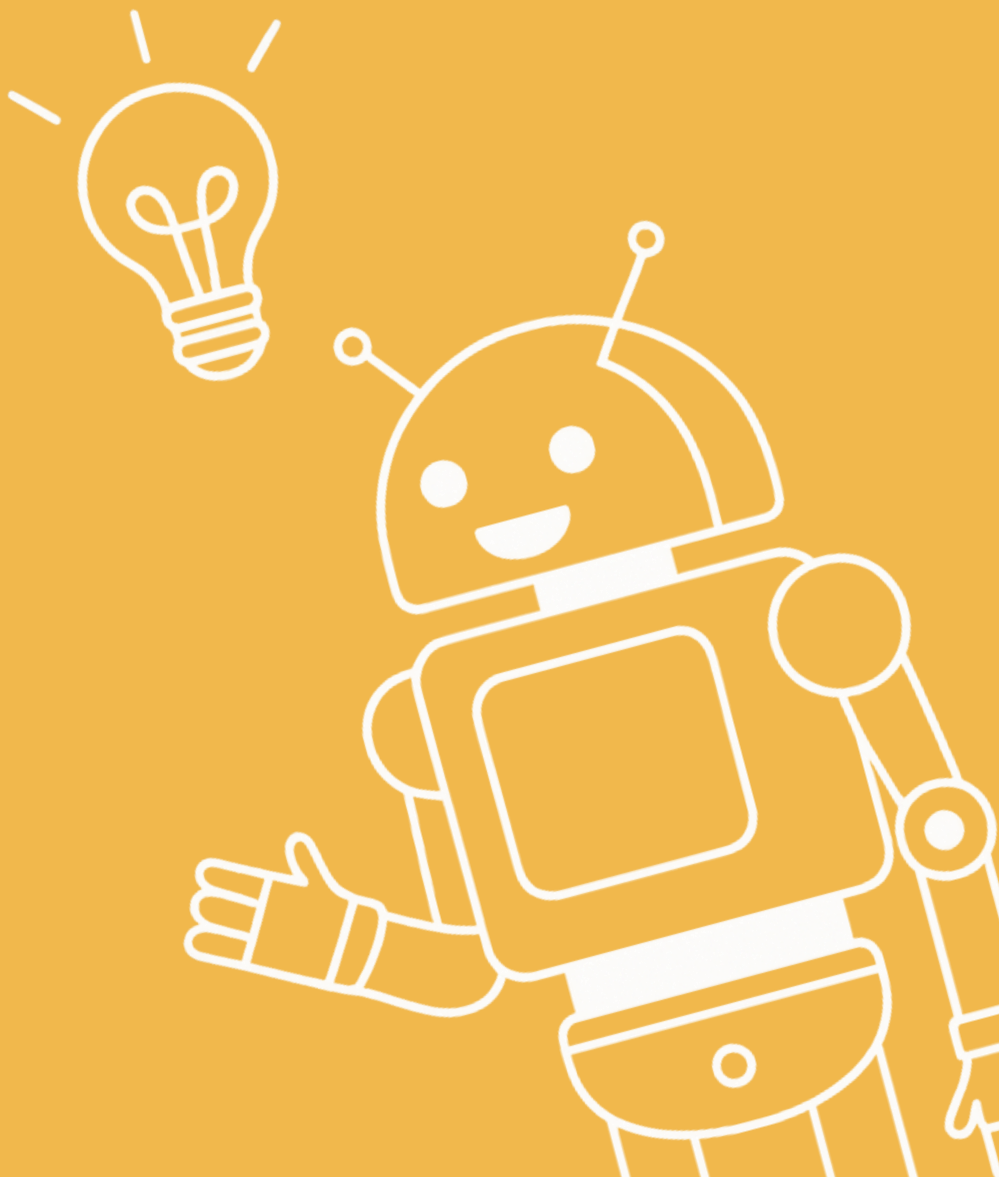
Gen AI will change our physical interface



Be where your customers are



Serve your customers better, faster, and easier





3

Lead the change

12

Use Gen AI to strengthen and rethink existing ambitions

13

Develop a roadmap of prioritized initiatives

14

Realize short term ROI using central capabilities

15

Reinvest productivity gains to improve your proposition

16

Design new propositions & business models now

17

Put your business in the lead and test-and-learn what works

18

Scale & replicate successes across the organization

Take a structured and considered approach

This chapter will be slightly different from the preceding ones.

Because while Gen AI is an exciting, new, and disruptive technology, dealing with it should not be about excitement and rushing along head-first into something new.

In fact, dealing with disruptive technologies requires the opposite: a structured, deliberate, organized, and even – dare we say it – boring approach towards structural value creation.

In the following pages we'll take you through 15 years of lessons on guiding organizations successfully through disruption in a practical and feasible way, moving from strategy all the way to on-the-ground change.

Don't let yourself be overwhelmed by this new technology, just treat it like any other challenge or opportunity facing your organization.

Lessons from digital

Wolters Kluwer identified digital disruption to its print business early. Rather than isolated pilots, it saw digital as a core transformation with clear goals and a roadmap of portfolio shifts, innovation investment, and talent transformation.

A strong customer focus remained central and was embedded in strict budgeting & innovation processes. Multi-year consistency, clear stakeholder communication and aligned incentives sustained momentum.

Result: Transformation from print publisher to Digital expert solution provider.



Use Gen AI to strengthen and rethink existing ambitions

Gen AI should never sit apart from your broader strategy. It is not a standalone goal but a means to an end, a tool to accelerate the ambitions you already have.

Start from your long-term vision, commercial priorities, and core KPIs, and then identify where Gen AI can remove bottlenecks, unlock new value, or help you reach those goals faster and at lower cost.

At the same time, leaders should revisit their strategic vision through the lens of Gen AI's disruptive potential. The technology may reshape customer expectations, shift value pools, or enable entirely new business models. Using Gen AI to strengthen your current agenda is essential. On top of that you should challenge if your current agenda is bold enough for the world now emerging.

Your responsibility

Set a vision & ambition reflecting the potential of Gen AI to both improve and disrupt your organization

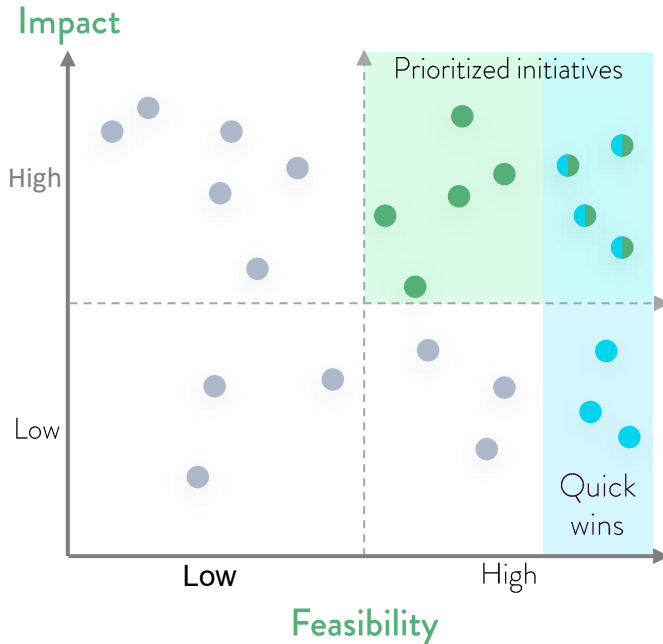
How to make it happen

- › Start with your current strategy and ambitions and structurally review where Gen AI can help reach goals faster and cheaper
- › Review value chains & customer journeys to assess where (added) value can be realized, or where disruption can happen

Contribution to **strategic goals**

Financial impact (costs, revenue)

Non-financial impact (quality, customer experience, sustainability, safety, etc.)



Required **investments**

Tech & data complexity

People & org change requirements

Legal & regulatory limitations

Develop a roadmap of prioritized initiatives

Once your strategic priorities are clear, you need to develop a clear roadmap, prioritizing initial quick wins to start generating value and creating enthusiasm quickly. At the same time, select your most impactful, business-critical (typically more complex) use cases to determine which requirements you need to put in place to realize them.

The simplest way to approach this is by categorizing initiatives on impact and feasibility based on clear criteria. This might seem obvious, but one of the key reasons many Gen AI initiatives don't scale, is that the wrong initiatives are executed – because they happen to pop up from the organization bottom-up, or because an employee found an interesting tool online. These initiatives typically fail to realize impact at scale.

Your responsibility

Develop a clear roadmap focused on both realizing quick wins and preparing for business-critical changes

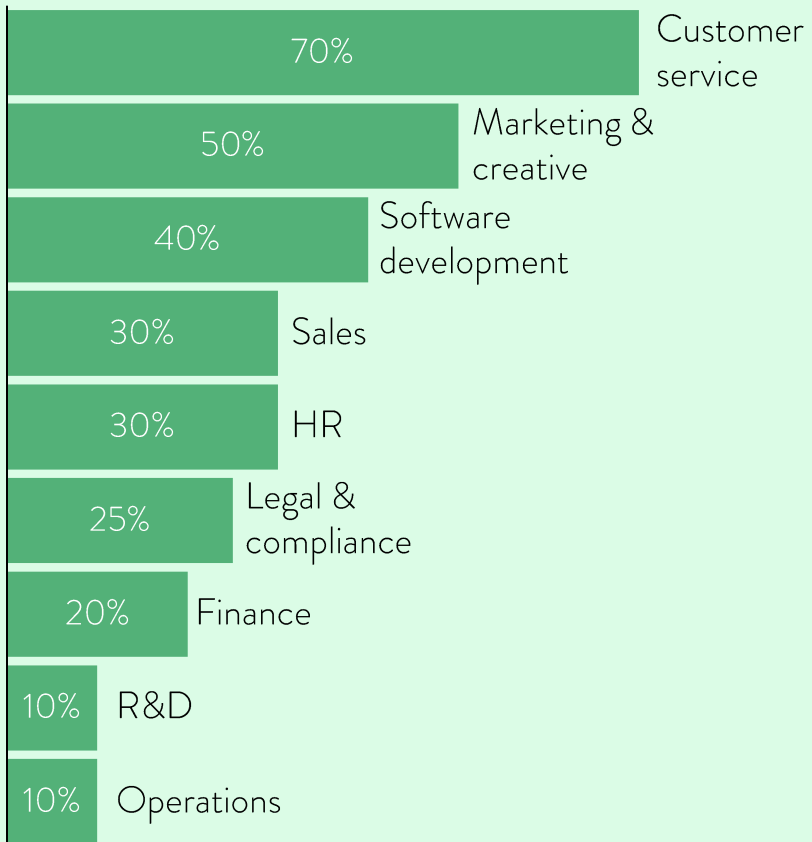
How to make it happen

- › Gather use cases from across the business bottom-up & top-down
- › Prioritize them on impact & feasibility
- › Select initial quick wins & detail requirements for business-critical use cases
- › Set up a flexible, stage-gated roadmap



SparkOptimus

Best in class Gen AI productivity gains (SparkOptimus Gen AI benchmark)



Realize short term ROI using central capabilities

Start realizing value rapidly with selected high-feasibility use cases. As we have seen before, Gen AI models are multi-purpose, so you do not need to build complex custom models for each use case. Most leading companies are approaching Gen AI this way, with our Gen AI benchmark showing 95 percent of companies work mostly or entirely with off-the-shelf models (e.g., ChatGPT or Gemini).

Where classic AI required many specialist roles, like data scientists, Gen AI allows you to get started with existing development capacity & capabilities. A typical approach to realizing value with simple use cases is to set up a center of excellence or AI hub to realize economies of scale and skill.

The fact that you can start quickly has another advantage: early wins quickly build momentum and enthusiasm across the organization.

Your responsibility

Realize high-feasibility use cases quickly, by ensuring sufficient resources are available

How to make it happen

- › Use central capabilities to build high-feasibility use cases quickly
- › Use existing development capacity
- › Utilize the power of off-the-shelf Gen AI models



Reinvest productivity gains to improve your proposition

Productivity gains are a no-brainer, but as we've seen, they are not where disruption happens. Real disruption occurs when you continuously evolve your customer proposition, serving customers better, faster, and easier.

A big advantage of Gen AI is that you can create short-term ROI quickly, allowing you to take some of the gains from AI-driven productivity to fund improvements on your customer proposition to create a lasting competitive edge.

A typical reallocation we see winners use is to spend about 10-30% of productivity gain wins on preparing for and realizing more fundamental transformation, depending on your industry and the maturity stage of your company.

Your responsibility

Allocate part of productivity gains to the broader Gen AI transformation

How to make it happen

- › *Determine the risk of disruption in your industry*
- › *Understand the maturity of your proposition in light of Gen AI*
- › *Determine which part of productivity gains to reinvest*



CUSTOMER NEEDS

goals pain points desires
value barriers feedback

Design new propositions & business models now

Once the impact of Gen AI on your strategy & ambitions are clear, you need to detail the exact approach to Gen AI proposition changes. And you should start now, because fundamentally reshaping propositions is a multi-year journey, not something you can fix quickly once the urgency is there.

This means understanding your customer needs, barriers, and opportunities. They are your starting point for clear business requirements, which you translate to technical & data requirements, which form the basis for a clear stage-gated roadmap.

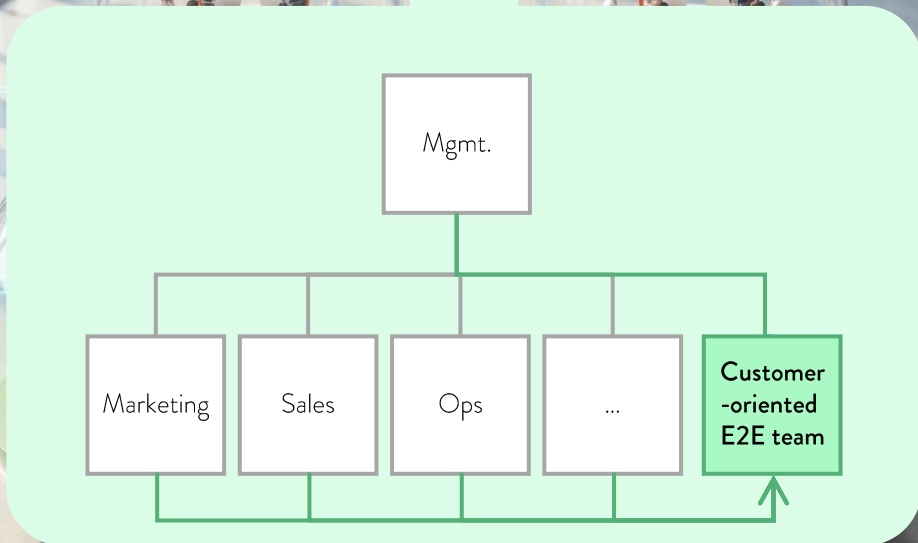
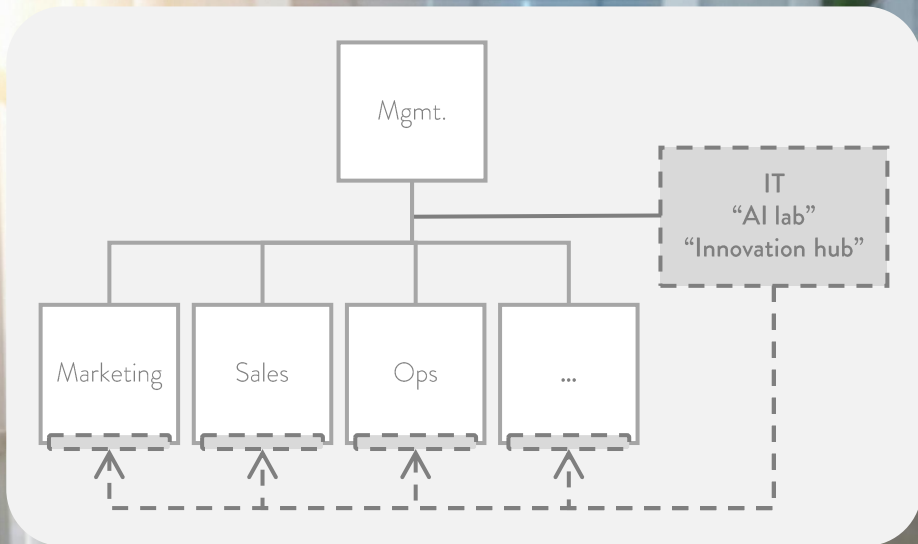
As these complex, foundational changes are long-term efforts, it is critical to allow for flexibility in the roadmap to continuously adapt your approach & evolve your proposition as customer needs become apparent and Gen AI model capabilities grow.

Your responsibility

*Design your future customer proposition
& business model*

How to make it happen

- › Understand your current customer needs & barriers in detail
- › Shape a future proposition to address those needs



Put your business in the lead and test-and-learn what works

The only way to drive real Gen AI transformation is to put the business, not IT, in the lead, and to do so through customer-oriented end-to-end teams. Traditional AI labs can help with simple productivity gains, but they are too far removed from customers and too siloed to reinvent the proposition; the scale of change required is simply too big to be driven from a central tech-focused function. Program management & governance can of course be run centrally.

The mandate of the end-to-end business teams is to learn fast at low risk: continuously testing with real customers, validating what truly creates value, and iterating based on feedback. Fast experimentation helps teams to de-risk ideas early and avoid scaling what does not work. Furthermore, initial successes can be shared quickly to boost enthusiasm more broadly.

Your responsibility

Start the transformation from the business and with real customers

How to make it happen

- › *Ringfence part of your business & customers*
- › *Iterate quickly to limit risk and learn what works*
- › *Communicate successes to boost enthusiasm*



Scale & replicate successes across the organization

Successful pilots in Gen AI are relatively common by now. Yet, scaling successes is rare, especially across BUs, functions, or markets. We shared common pitfalls in scaling in chapter 1 and will address several solutions in the next chapter on foundation elements.

We very often see organizations make ‘scaling playbooks’, assuming BUs/markets will implement them successfully. But in our experience, many prerequisites are often forgotten in these playbooks:

- Where does funding come from?
- How is adoption incentivized (on an employee and BU/market level)?
- What is the change management approach?
- How is continuous improvement put in place (especially in complex multi-tiered organizations)?
- Where do we expect change resistance?

Your responsibility

Understand your organization’s barriers in scaling innovation & take them away

How to make it happen

- › *Develop a playbook for scaling Gen AI successes*
- › *Include your approach to taking away frequent roadblocks like a lack of funding, low adoption, and resistance to change*
- › *Execute the playbook rigorously*

Key lessons

12 Use Gen AI to strengthen and rethink existing ambitions

13 Develop a roadmap of prioritized initiatives

14 Realize short term ROI using central capabilities

15 Reinvest productivity gains to improve your proposition

16 Design new propositions & business models now

17 Put your business in the lead and test-and-learn what works

18 Scale & replicate successes across the organization

What it looks like in practice: a case example



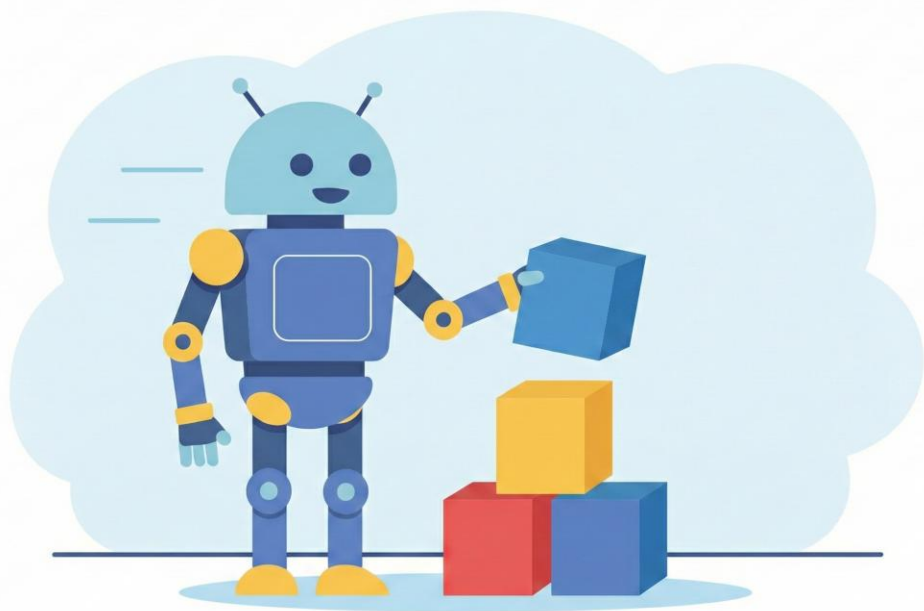
A global CPG player saw a big opportunity in using Gen AI to help their customers grow their business – one of their customers' key needs. However, their initial initiatives were not realizing the value they expected.

We began by revisiting the company's commercial ambitions, updating targets like campaign ROI and sales outreach to reflect Gen AI potential. We set a clear vision for key areas most impacted by Gen AI in the coming years, like sales and logistics.

Through workshops & data gathering, we identified and then prioritized 100+ Gen AI use cases across departments. We focused on realizing quick wins in a few FTE-heavy departments, leveraging development capacity in the existing IT team and focusing on off-the-shelf OpenAI models: IT (30% faster code development), marketing (25% faster campaign & content creation), and customer service (30% increased efficiency).

But that wasn't all. Based on the Gen AI enabled vision for the sales department we started putting in place the foundation for this future way of working. This included making improvements in sell-out data quality but also interviewing many customers and consumers to understand the barriers in our client's current service model to refine the future proposition.

We started testing elements of this new proposition with a small Sales team in a single city, gathering feedback continuously to iterate every single part of the proposition. Several use cases proved their value quickly, including an improved churn prediction model, which we rolled out to all sales reps nationwide with a strong scaling playbook and funding model.



4

Create a strong foundation



Create a strong foundation

Successfully realizing short-term impact, reshaping your business model & customer proposition, and scaling & replicating successful initiatives across the organization, does not come for free.

As we've said before, it requires a structured and deliberate approach, which also means paying the required attention to foundational elements. In our benchmarks and at our clients, we see 6 main elements pop up again and again as prerequisites for success:

20

Leadership alignment

21

People-first change journey

22

Program management & KPIs

23

Digital, data, and cybersecurity

24

Legal & compliance

25

Ethics & responsible AI



Leadership alignment

Our benchmark shows that 50% of companies struggle with a lack of management attention or alignment.

This friction occurs when boards view Gen AI through different lenses—some as a cost-cutter, others as a growth engine, and some as a risk. This is made more complex by the fact that AI models are often seen as (and somewhat are) a black box and that board education on understanding Gen AI is often still needed.

To succeed in navigating disruption, you need to agree on a single consistent strategy & corresponding narrative, building a shared language. But this alignment goes beyond just agreeing on the vision; it requires a shared commitment to execution. This means making hard choices as a team: allocating scarce resources, determining what to prioritize, and killing your darlings.

Showing a united leadership team with buy-in on Gen AI removes ambiguity for the rest of the organization, ensuring teams focus their efforts in the right areas, instead of wasting resources and energy.

What to ask yourself

- › *Do we fully understand the opportunities & risks of Gen AI?*
- › *Do we agree on an aligned strategy?*
- › *Do we speak as one voice, and with one language, towards all of our stakeholders?*



People-first change journey

In the end, any transformation is 80% people and just 20% technology. This is even truer for Gen AI, as jobs and ways of working will change fast for most people when hybrid agentic-human teams become the new norm. You need to understand the effect of the transformation on your people.

Start with your future customer proposition and business model, and determine what processes & capabilities are needed to deliver them. Then build the required organization model: which roles change, which new ones arise, and which ones disappear.

Guiding this transformation requires continuous change management based on a clear roadmap for people transformation. Continuously upskill and reskill people to guide them through the transformation; incentivize people to grow with the change; and communicate a clear change story – focused on “what’s in it for me” – to maintain trust and momentum.

Gen AI succeeds when organizations treat it as a people-led redesign of work, supported by a disciplined roadmap and active leadership involvement.

What to ask yourself

- › *Is there a specific roadmap for people transformation?*
- › *Do we have a view on what our organization looks like in 5 years?*
- › *Do we have a clear change story?*

Example Gen AI KPIs



Innovation quality

Throughput (backlog-> pilot-> scale)

Cost of stopped pilots

Impact-feasibility accuracy

...



Pilot success

Adoption rate

Accuracy & reliability

Process impact (*dependent on pilot goal*)

...



Business impact

Customer satisfaction

Revenue uplift & top-line growth

Efficiency gains & bottom-line impact

...

Program management & KPIs

Managing a Gen AI transformation requires more than just a list of ideas. Rigorous program management is needed to manage the portfolio of short-term initiatives and broader proposition changes.

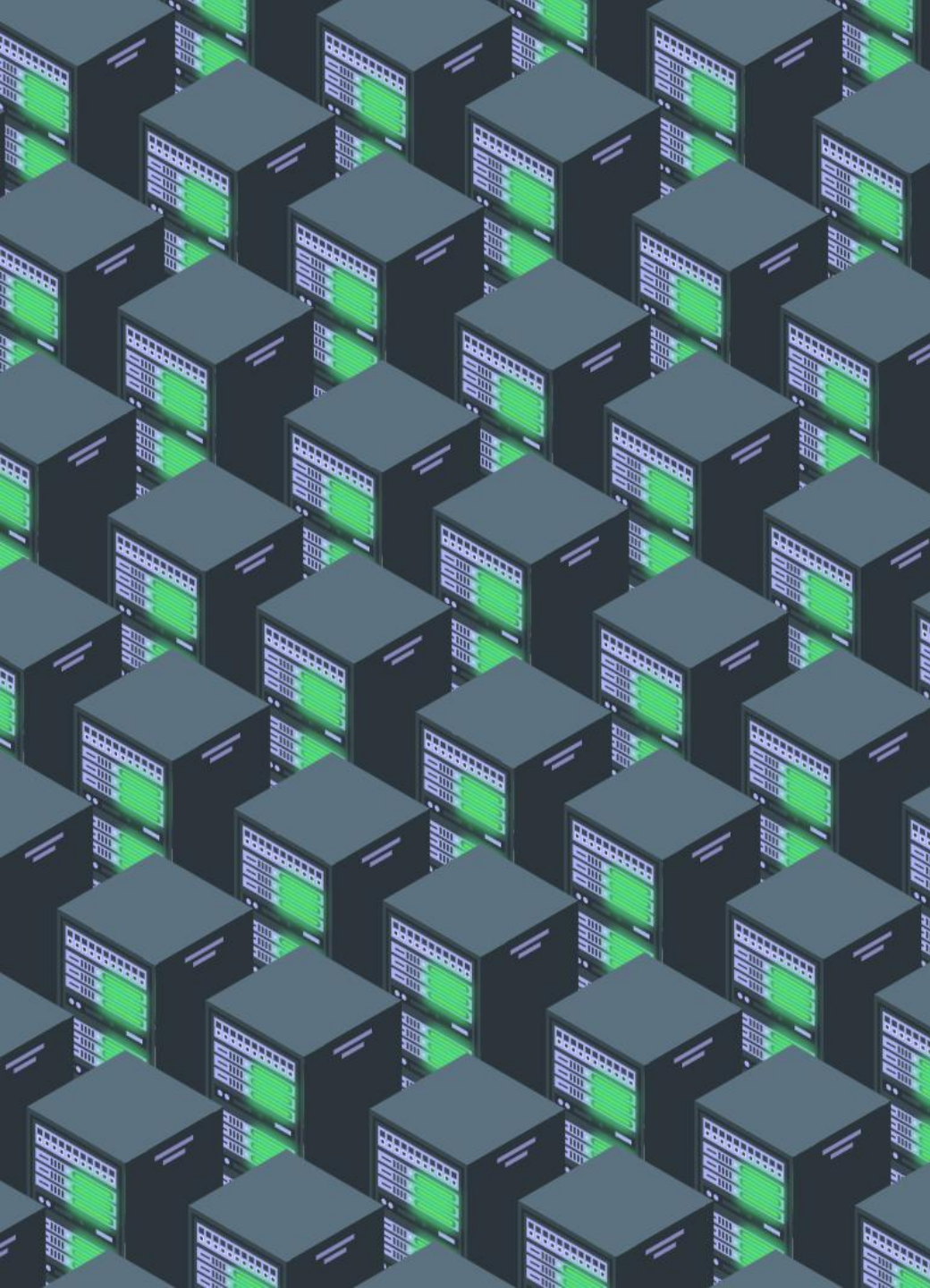
The goal here is to ensure continuous focus on what works. This means a continuous mapping of business challenges and opportunities to identify use cases; consistent & standardized prioritization of use cases; maintaining speed in pilot development; stopping unsuccessful use cases; and determining how and when to scale successes.

All the above should be done in a data-driven way, requiring clear guidelines & KPIs on use case development & testing, measuring both pilot success, impact at scale, and employee change.

These are not things you can ‘let happen’, they require a considered approach and dedicated resources.

What to ask yourself

- › *Do we have a central overview and governance for everything we do on Gen AI?*
- › *Are we structurally tracking value creation?*



Digital, Data, and Cybersecurity

Building agentic AI solutions is only possible when your digital, data, and security foundations are strong. These fundamentals have always been important, with cybersecurity taking an especially prominent role given today's geopolitical landscape. But with systems that can act autonomously across workflows, they become business-critical. You can build an impressive interface, but without integrated, reliable data underneath, it simply will not work. An agentic AI travel platform, for example, only becomes useful when it can draw on hotel reviews, real-time availability, pricing, and personalized customer insights to act on behalf of a user.

While simple Gen AI use cases can be built on legacy IT, true agentic systems will require access to sensitive data, tools, and core operational platforms. This means organizations need to decide early what these systems are allowed to access and under which conditions. Clear permissions, controlled interfaces, and strong oversight mechanisms are essential. Getting these foundations right from the start not only enables more capable agentic AI solutions, but it also ensures they can operate safely and reliably at scale.

What to ask yourself

- › *Are we using off-the-shelf Gen AI solutions for simple use cases?*
- › *Are we working on data, digital, and cybersecurity fundamentals for our core strategic priorities?*



Legal & compliance

While heavily regulated industries like banking & healthcare feel most pressure, the need for an integrated legal and compliance approach is felt everywhere. With 30% of companies citing legal hurdles as a scaling barrier, these functions cannot simply remain gatekeepers at the end of the process.

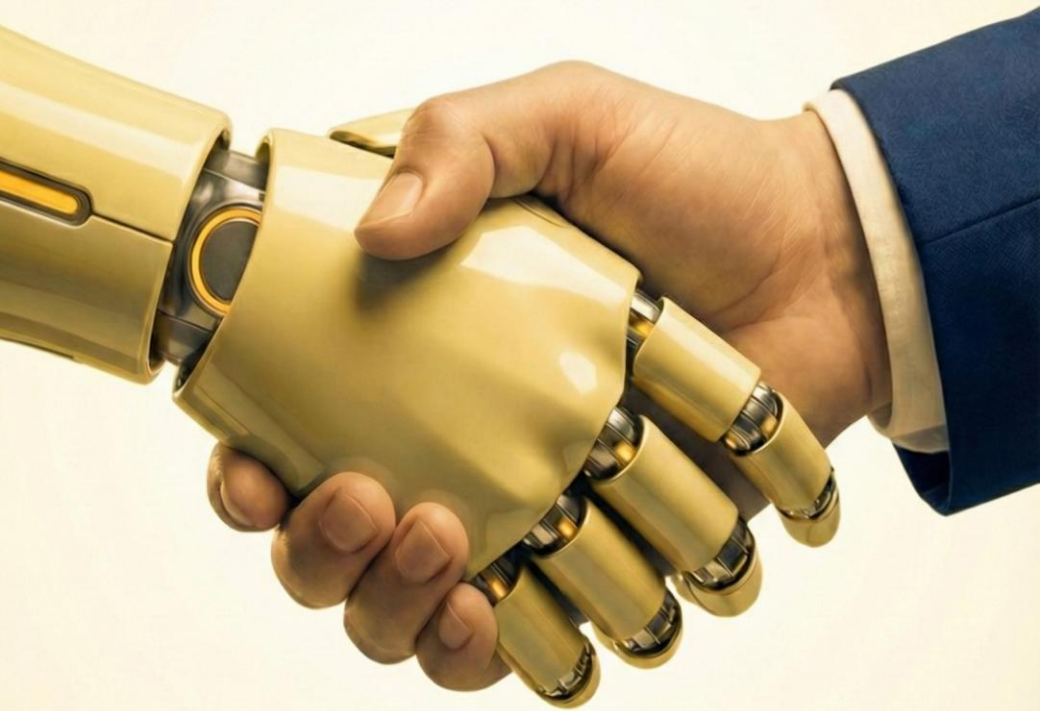
Instead, they must become active partners involved at every stage of the process: from the initial prioritization of use cases to pilot monitoring, all the way to scaling plans and (international) rollout.

As regulation continues to grow, the only way to maintain speed is to operationalize these requirements rather than ignore them. Teams need a clear, accessible overview of what is and isn't allowed to remove ambiguity. This does not mean 'no' is the default: legal & compliance must also adapt to this new reality and define what risks are acceptable and which aren't.

The best practice is setting up a tiered approach: simple self-assessments for new ideas, high-level checklists for rapid, low-risk pilots, and full legal & compliance frameworks for scaling solutions

What to ask yourself

- › *Are legal & compliance teams involved at the right moment, allowing for speed while not becoming a barrier once scaling?*



Ethics & responsible AI

Ethical conduct in Gen AI is not a compliance exercise, it is a leadership responsibility. Boards and executives shape how broadly and how fast AI will be deployed in their organization, and with that comes accountability for trust, fairness, and long-term impact.

Gen AI introduces new business-critical types of risk: hallucination, bias, copyright challenges, and fundamental changes of employee roles. As organizations move to more autonomous, agentic systems, the stakes increase further: actions are taken with less human oversight and roles change even more.

Thus, clear guidelines on what you will and will not do with AI are needed and can in fact help accelerate adoption by removing ambiguity. These guidelines should be embedded throughout the innovation lifecycle, from ideation, to testing, to scaling. This is a cross-functional matter: HR, legal, compliance, privacy, and management together need to shape it together.

What to ask yourself

- › *Do we have clear red lines on where not to apply Gen AI?*
- › *Do we have a view on workforce impact & how to deal with it?*
- › *Are all relevant roles included in the cross-functional team responsible for our transformation?*

Key foundations



Leadership alignment



People-first change journey



Program management & KPIs



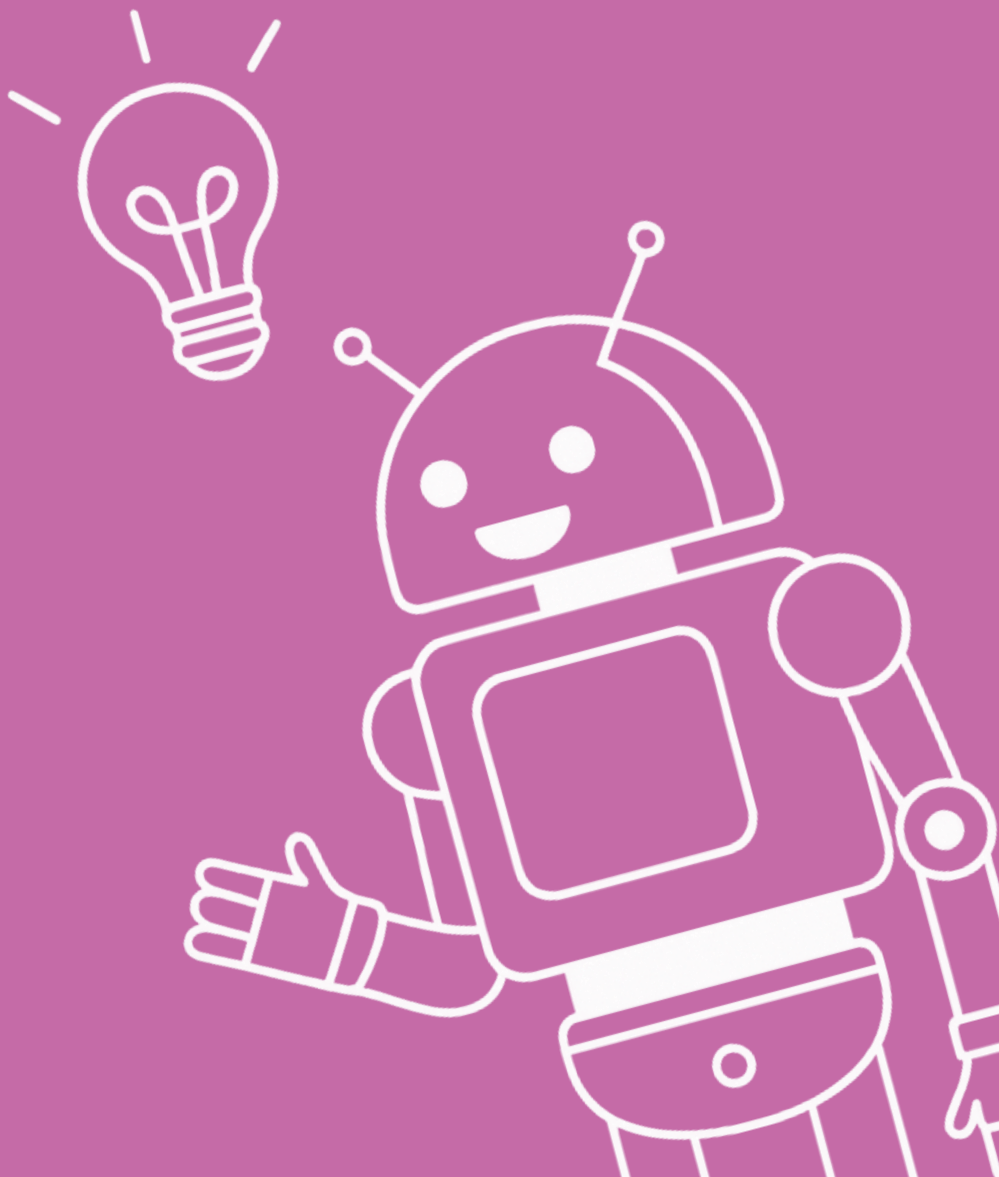
Digital, data, and cybersecurity



Legal & compliance



Ethics & responsible AI



Key questions for board members: Leading the change

Do your **vision & ambition** reflect the potential **impact** of Gen AI?

Is there a **continuously updated roadmap** focused on quick wins and more business-critical changes?

Are you already **realizing productivity gains** in individual functions?

Do you **understand who could be the new disruptors** that will own your customers?

Are you experimenting with Gen AI to **create new customer experiences**?

Are you putting the **business in the lead** and testing **with real customers**?

Key questions for board members: Foundation

Is there an **educated & aligned board speaking with one voice and language** towards the organization?

Is there a **clear roadmap for people transformation** based on a strong change story?

Is there a **governance and KPI-driven value tracking approach** for Gen AI initiatives?

Are you working on **data, digital, and cybersecurity fundamentals** for your core strategic priorities?

Are **legal & compliance teams involved at the right moment**, allowing for speed?

Are **responsible AI principles** in place with clear red lines?

Our Services

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Strategy

Shape a Gen AI-ready strategy & vision based on Gen AI disruption, identify where the value is, design new propositions, and develop a clear approach

Transformation

Future-proof your organization end-to-end, realize ROI quickly, set up customer-facing teams & reshape the proposition, while building the foundation

Kickstart

Get a pragmatic start with AI value creation to build enthusiasm in the organization & show early proof points in as little as 6-8 weeks



What our clients say sets us apart

- › **We understand Gen AI like no other** & can make it simple, concrete, and actionable
- › **We show value every step of the way** to create self-funding projects
- › **We take an end-to-end approach**, with limited client resources needed
- › **We take a broader perspective than just Gen AI**, focused on creating the best customer proposition
- › **We work with everyone**, from C-level strategy to on-the-ground change management

SparkOptimus

